campaigning by the RSS. Actually, its success is largely due to the fact that it can do good old-fashioned door-to-door campaigning which Congress has lost the art of doing. We used to do that in the 1950s, ’60s and ’70s. I have seen records of that. After that, we started depending on a charismatic figure and felt that there was no need to do this kind of campaigning.’

‘It is easy to over-emphasise the importance of social media,’ he says. ‘Social media plays a supplementary role in my view, an atmosphere-creating role, but it is not a decisive role. It doesn’t substitute for ground politics. I agree BJP was able to deploy good old-style door-to-door campaigning much more effectively and, of course, they also have a multiplicity of campaigners. It enables them to play the good cop, bad cop routine. PM can be above the fray and it is left to Amit Shah and the others to do all the mudslinging and run an incendiary campaign. We also have a multiplicity of voices but unfortunately, the media focuses only on the Gandhis because they think only that is important.’

The BJP’s Rollover Ticket Strategy

One of the under-appreciated facets of the 2019 general election is that the BJP changed 115 of its sitting MPs who, it thought, would lose due to local anti-incumbency. The party ended up winning 86 per cent (ninety-nine) of these seats. The ruthlessness on ticket distribution helped the party overcome the hazard of incumbency. This is an old strategy for Modi and Shah, one they had used in the Gujarat assembly elections in the past, where it was common for a large number of sitting MLAs not to have their tickets renewed. Now they replicated it in Delhi. It is possible that, in a wave election, as this one was, the BJP would have won many of these seats anyway. People vote due to a complex matrix of factors, but last-mile campaign strategies do make a difference. In this, the contrast between the two parties was stark.

Message Discipline Mattered